

Capitalization & Possessives

Study Guide - Language & Editing

1. Learning goal

Capitalize proper names and formal titles correctly and use apostrophes to show possession or contractions without confusing them with plurals.

2. What this skill means

Capitalization marks proper names, calendar names, and certain formal titles. Apostrophes show possession or omitted letters in contractions; they do not make ordinary nouns plural. Possessive pronouns such as *its*, *yours*, and *theirs* do not use apostrophes.

3. Do not confuse it with

Its shows possession; *it's* means it is or it has. *Guides* is plural; *guide's* means belonging to one guide; *guides'* means belonging to multiple guides. Capitalize *Monday* and *September*, but not common nouns such as *meeting* or *program* unless they are part of a proper name.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask for the correctly capitalized sentence, the correct singular or plural possessive, or the correct form of *its/it's* and similar words.

5. Repeatable method

- Decide whether each name is proper or common.
- Check whether a title is used as part of a person's name or generically.
- For apostrophes, decide plural or singular before deciding possession.
- Test contractions by expanding them: *it's* → *it is/it has*.
- Reread the noun phrase to confirm who owns what.

6. Worked example

The guides' schedules were posted on Monday, and the museum updated its website that afternoon.

Question: Why do *guides'* and *its* use different forms?

Reasoning: Guides' is a plural noun showing possession, so it takes an apostrophe after s. Its is a possessive pronoun, so it never takes an apostrophe.

Best answer: Use guides' for possession by multiple guides and its for the museum's possession.

7. Common traps

- Adding apostrophes to ordinary plurals.
- Confusing its with it's.
- Capitalizing common nouns merely because they seem important.

8. Diagnostic help

- If apostrophes are difficult, first write the plain plural or singular noun, then add possession.
- If you choose it's, expand it to it is. If the sentence breaks, use its.
- If capitalization feels uncertain, ask whether the word names one specific official person/place/date or an ordinary category.

Why this matters in ER: Correct mechanics support the Standard English trait in the ER, but clarity and accurate reasoning still matter more than decorative formality.

9. Quick check

Dr. Maya Chen will speak on Tuesday, and the students' questions will be collected afterward.

Which words are capitalized or possessive, and why?

Check yourself: Dr. Maya Chen and Tuesday are proper-name/calendar forms; students' shows possession by multiple students.